

knowledge and expertise for the innovative tools we aimed to develop. One of our core products originated in India, created by the renowned Satish Dharmaraj. This product, named Zimbra, served as one of our initial components, later enhanced with additional functionality. Over the past decade, we have collaborated with 300-400 developers from various parts of India, spanning Kerala, Gujarat, New Delhi, Mumbai, and Bangalore. This collaboration resulted in an integrated, feature-rich suite of products. We maintain strong relations with many of these developers and are proud to have initiated this venture from Switzerland and India.

Q. Is India only relevant to you because of its developer community or are you also looking at it as a potential market?

A. Unfortunately, India presents a unique challenge for selling software due to it being a software development powerhouse. Many Indian software development companies find it challenging to pay for software, asserting that as a nation of software development, they shouldn't have to pay or, at the very least, not as much.

Q. When running multiple platforms, how does the licensing model play out?

A. We have a core component called VNCdirectory, a directory service and integration platform similar to Microsoft Active Directory, for managing organisations, sub-organisations, users, and roles. In VNCdirectory, you can define permissions, such as allowing a specific group of users in an organisation or sub-organisation, or with a certain role (e.g., marketing) to use VNCchannels. User activity is tracked, allowing us to generate detailed reports. We trust our partners, and the invoicing process is straightforward, with monthly invoices sent based on actual usage — for example, if 10,000 users are using VNCchannels.

Q. What kind of licences do you use for your open source platform — traditional open source licences, or source available licences, and why?

A. We must find common ground. The minimum, or least possible denominator, as it's called, is quite straightforward for us. We adhere to the General Public Licence (GPL), specifically the latest version. Given the multitude of components within our stack, there are automated tools that consistently check the tools used in a given environment, along with the associated licences. So, we always aim for a licence that comprehensively covers everything, typically opting for GPL. Regarding licensing changes when the product is passed on to our partners and they make modifications, the licensing component itself remains unchanged. The product undergoes customisation as needed. Yes, the stack we deliver is under the GPL, and if a partner decides to enhance functionality for a particular project, they have the freedom to do so. There's no obligation to contribute it back, except if they intend to resell it — in that case, adhering to the licensing requirements would be appreciated. This sometimes leads to misunderstandings with open source; developing open source in a project doesn't necessitate sharing it unless there's an intention to resell it.

Q. Are there any new developments or additions to the technology stack of your product?

A. In terms of our future developments, we are currently in the beta phase of introducing a low-code/no-code platform to our stack. This platform empowers managers and government administrators to interact with data from VNClagoon's backend. They can build tables, charts, and even geo-mapping without the need for coding skills. The strength of low-code/no-code lies in its front-end tools that

allow manipulation and interaction with applications and data, akin to a pivot table in a spreadsheet.

Another addition in our agenda is the incorporation of AI tools. Many discussions around AI often focus on statistics or, at best, machine learning. However, we are actively integrating a variety of AI tools into our stack. For instance, we are collaborating with a large German customer managing billions of documents, some even handwritten. To digitise such information efficiently, we are embedding machine learning capabilities into our product. This is just one example, and we are also developing AI applications within project management. An exciting project in collaboration with an AI expert in Mumbai involves creating a 'robot planning' feature. This AI analyses a developer's behaviour and ticket information to streamline and prioritise tasks automatically, enhancing productivity. These AI and machine learning additions are progressively becoming part of our product stack.

Q. How secure is the code if AI is a part of the development process?

A. The question you raised is indeed a challenge, shedding light on a significant issue with AI. It's crucial to address concerns about privacy and data security when feeding models with our own and our customers' data. The idea of government institutions handing over data to external entities like Google TensorFlow or ChatGPT raises valid concerns about national sovereignty. Operating in this manner poses risks, making it imperative to always closely monitor and adapt our approach to AI.

To mitigate these risks, the preference should be for AI models that are prebuilt and installed locally. By keeping the data within your control, you feed it into the model, enhancing precision and facilitating learning. Crucially, this approach ensures that the model's insights remain private,